

CONFERENCE CALL NOTES: US-Mexico

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【要点】

- ・ USMCA（米国・メキシコ・カナダ協定）の全面的な見直しの確率は5%に過ぎず、基本シナリオは「ゾンビUSMCA」であり、三国間交渉が減少し二国間プロトコルが増加すると予想される。
- ・ メキシコはカナダよりも交渉で有利な立場にあるものの、柔軟性が見返りが少なく、9月の交渉は延期される見込みで、2027年第1四半期まで交渉が延びる可能性が高い。
- ・ メキシコへの投資の主な障害は二国間の貿易摩擦ではなく国内制約であり、特に送電網などのエネルギーインフラが最大の課題で、司法改革と治安問題も悪影響を与えている。
- ・ メキシコは鉄鋼・アルミ関税の対象であり、過度な製造能力に関する調査にも直面しており、米国に対する商品貿易黒字の拡大も交渉圧力になっている。

【メール原文】

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Eurasia Group places the odds of a full review of the US-Mexico-Canada Agreement (USMCA) at only 5%, and the basecase remains a “zombie USMCA” in which bilateral protocols increasingly replace trilateral dealmaking through the rest of President Donald Trump's administration.

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Mexico is better positioned than Canada in the negotiations but has little to show for its greater flexibility, and talks with Mexico in September will probably be postponed, which would slow the negotiating timeline and increase the chances that discussions extend into at least the first quarter of 2027.

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Domestic constraints, rather than bilateral trade friction, remain the main obstacle to investment in Mexico, with energy infrastructure, especially transmission, as the primary bottleneck and judicial reform and security concerns creating additional headwinds.

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Speakers:

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The Zombie USMCA: Base Case and Tail Risks

Eurasia Group's base case is a "zombie USMCA": the agreement remains legally in force through 2036 but is not comprehensively renegotiated, revitalized, or materially updated during Trump's current term. Instead, new trade disputes and market-access issues will increasingly be managed through bilateral US-Mexico and US-Canada protocols rather than through a trilateral framework.

A full trilateral agreement remains a tail risk, with Eurasia Group assigning it only a 5% probability. A unilateral US withdrawal is also considered highly unlikely. The most likely outcome is therefore an extended period of "uncertainty within guardrails" — USMCA continues to anchor North American trade, but businesses face a more fragmented, ad hoc, and volatile negotiating environment with greater friction around individual sectors and products.

Mexico vs. Canada: Better Positioned, Not Better Off — Yet

Despite Canada's more confrontational posture, Mexico and Canada currently face broadly similar tariff burdens. Mexico remains subject to Section 232 tariffs on steel and aluminum and is also facing a Section 301 investigation into alleged excess manufacturing capacity, which does not apply to Canada. Mexico's growing goods trade surplus with the US — now larger than China's — is also becoming an increasingly important source of pressure in the negotiations.

Mexico's main advantage is that bilateral negotiations with Washington remain active while US-Canada talks are suspended. The government has also moved to strengthen its negotiating position by submitting a revised Foreign Investment Law that would introduce national-security screening and facilitate greater coordination with the US on foreign investment, particularly from China. The measure builds on discussions initiated with the US Treasury in 2023 and could support Mexico's broader strategy of tightening external barriers in exchange for lower trade barriers within North America.

The expectation is therefore that Mexico will reach an agreement with the US before Canada does. However, Mexico's greater flexibility has yet to produce significant concessions, and it remains unclear whether an earlier agreement would ultimately translate into materially better terms.

Key Negotiating Issues

Three issues are consuming most of the bilateral bandwidth:

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Auto rules of origin: The US proposes 82.5% regional value content with 50% US-specific value added. Mexico is willing to go to 90% regional value content but rejects a US-only floor. Resolution likely requires a trilateral framework.

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Steel tariffs (Section 232): President Claudia Sheinbaum has personally flagged steel tariff relief as a political necessity. No resolution yet.

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Agricultural exports and trade balance: Seasonal restrictions on Mexican tomato exports are a live concern; there is a direct security linkage — Sinaloa produces the bulk of Mexico's tomatoes, and export restrictions could push agricultural workers toward cartel recruitment.

Progress has been made on approximately 54 Mexican non-tariff barriers, most of which appear in the USTR's National Trade Estimate Report. The US can announce wins selectively; a pre-midterm package announcement is possible but not confirmed. Formal negotiations scheduled for September in Washington were postponed; the earliest new date is October, pushing a comprehensive deal possibly into at least Q1 2027.

Security: A Friction, Not Yet a Dealbreaker

US security operations in Mexico have expanded under Trump, increasing pressure on the bilateral relationship. Sheinbaum has managed the tension by publicly framing US actions as part of a cooperative security effort, even when coordination has been more limited in practice. The indictment of a sitting Mexican politician neared a political red line, though Sheinbaum has so far contained the fallout without allowing it to derail broader bilateral engagement.

The more consequential red line would be unilateral US military action on Mexican territory, including unauthorized drone operations or strikes against drug laboratories. Such a move would significantly complicate trade negotiations and create domestic political pressure on Sheinbaum, but would not necessarily bring talks to an end. For now, security cooperation remains deep, particularly between US agencies and Security Minister Omar Garcia, while high-level diplomatic engagement with Washington continues.

Investment Climate: The Domestic Drag

The weakness in new investment into Mexico is being driven primarily by domestic constraints rather than US-Mexico trade friction. The most important is energy: Mexico does not have sufficient capacity to meet current demand, therefore additional investment in data centers and manufacturing would face growing difficulty securing reliable, clean, and competitively priced power. Security-related costs, particularly for transportation and logistics, are a secondary headwind.

Judicial reform adds another layer of uncertainty, particularly through weaker access to injunctions and more limited investor protections. However, the practical impact has so far been more contained than initially feared, with some regulatory institutions continuing to operate in a relatively timely and rules-based manner.

Mexico is also trying to diversify its investment relationships by deepening ties with the European Union, Japan and Brazil. Its recently updated trade agreement with the EU supports that strategy, although provisions on geographic indications have created a new source of friction with Washington.

Key Watch Items

1.

Formal negotiation timeline: Whether postponed September talks are rescheduled for October and whether a deal framework emerges before Q1 2027.

2.

Section 232 steel tariff relief: Sheinbaum has staked political credibility on this; failure to achieve movement increases her domestic pressure to harden her position.

3.

US unilateral security actions: Any drone strike or boots-on-the-ground operation in Mexico without authorization would cross a stated red line and materially complicate trade talks.

4.

Auto rules of origin resolution: Whether the US-only value-added floor can be negotiated away; this likely requires Canada's return to the table.

5.

Mexico's foreign investment law: Senate passage and implementation will determine whether Mexico can convert its China-screening cooperation into tangible tariff concessions from the US.

6.

Energy bottleneck: Whether Mexico can expand reliable energy capacity fast enough to sustain nearshoring momentum; this is the single largest constraint on FDI according to one speaker.

What Clients Are Asking

Timeline for a US-Mexico deal: No firm deadline was identified for an agreement. Washington has enough progress on individual issues to announce incremental deals at any point, but a broader package — particularly one involving automotive rules of origin — would likely require trilateral participation. With the September negotiating round postponed and no replacement date yet announced, talks are increasingly likely to extend into at least Q1 2027.

Whether Mexico's flexibility is paying off: Mexico has nothing to show for its accommodating posture relative to Canada, which has been confrontational. The gap in outcomes so far is narrower than the gap in approach, which is a source of domestic political tension for Sheinbaum.

China's role in Mexico: Clients asked about Chinese investment flows. Mexico, unlike most of Latin America, has its own reasons to restrict Chinese trade and investment — a large bilateral trade deficit with China and long-standing distrust — and that US and Mexican preferences are broadly aligned. One noted tension: the US is permitting some Chinese-owned investment domestically (Volvo was cited as an example) while pressuring Mexico to restrict it.

Regulatory and judicial reforms impact on investors: US and Mexican companies diverged in their concerns. Mexican companies were more alarmed; US companies took a more pragmatic wait-and-see approach. So far, key regulatory bodies have continued to function adequately. The bigger practical issue is the weakening of injunction rights and the reduced scope of ISDS protections, which is prompting discussion of alternative mechanisms including specialized trade courts and political risk insurance through multilateral development banks.

Whether Sheinbaum might simply wait out Trump: Waiting out Trump is already part of Mexico's strategy. Mexico does not expect the post-midterm US environment to differ materially on trade. The goal is to reduce uncertainty and tariff levels as much as possible now, with the expectation that structural uncertainty will only meaningfully decline under the next US administration.

Please note that while this AI-generated summary has been checked for accuracy against the source material, it may not capture every nuance or qualifier from the discussion. The full transcript or audio should be consulted for complete context.

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